Communication and Information Acquisition in Committees

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  1. Does it increase or decrease information acquisition? *(Key question)*
  2. How does it affect group accuracy and welfare?

Preview of this paper

Setting: a common-interest group decides by majority voting; info is costly

Institution comparison:

$$\text{Information acquisition} \longrightarrow \text{Voting} \quad \text{(e.g. Persico 2004)}$$

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Main findings:

- **Theory**: Communication can increase or decrease information acquisition, depending on information costs. Likewise for group accuracy and welfare.
- **Experiment**: Communication increases acquisition and group outcomes. The downside is missing as subjects overvalue their own acquisition under communication.

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1. Information acquisition in collective decisions
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2. Deliberation in collective decisions
   - Prior work: aggregation of given information. e.g. Coughlan 2000; Gerardi and Yariv 2007; Goeree and Yariv 2011; Iaryczower et al. 2018
   - This paper: deliberation also affects costly information provision!

Theory

Setup

- A three-player group decides between options A and B via majority voting.
  ($N = 2n + 1$ in the paper.)
- State A or B occurs equally likely. Players do not observe the state but have correct prior.
- Players have common interests: everyone receives payoff 1 if the group decision matches the true state, and 0 otherwise.

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Equilibrium concept and post-acquisition subgame

I focus on *symmetric, neutral* PBEs under two restrictions:

- weakly undominated voting strategies (as in the voting literature)
- maximal information transmission (as in the cheap-talk literature)

In equilibrium,

- **Sincere voting:** vote according to the posterior (randomize between two votes equally when uninformed in NC)
- **Full revelation:** communication makes all private information common knowledge

Equilibria are characterised by information acquisition strategies.

Core Intuition: Why communication matters?

Given the others' strategies, a player's incentive to buy signal:

$$U(Buy) - U(NotBuy) = \underbrace{Pr(piv) \times (q - \frac{1}{2})}_{\text{Expected increase in group accuracy}} - c$$

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$\rightarrow$ not align in the two games!

Communication's effect on incentive

Case I: Neither P1 nor P2 buys.

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Persuasion effect (+): Communication amplifies **one's own signal's** influence, making acquisition more valuable.

- In NC, a signal affects only one's own vote. Communication allows it to sway others' votes.

Communication's effect on incentive

Case II: One buys, one does not. E.g., P1 buys, P2 does not, $q \approx 1$ same for general q

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- In C, P3's signal adds no value.
- In NC, P3's signal matters if $v_1 \neq v_2$.

Substitution effect (-): Communication amplifies **others' signals'** influence, making one's own signal less necessary.

- In NC, uninformed votes may offset informed votes. Communication removes this noise.

Communication's effect on incentive

Case III: Both P1 and P2 buy.

- In C, P3's signal matters if $s_1 \neq s_2$.
- In NC, P3's signal matters if $v_1 \neq v_2$. This is equivalent to $s_1 \neq s_2$.

$\rightarrow$ No effect of communication in this case.

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Case III: Both P1 and P2 buy.

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Summary:

1. Neither buys: Persuasion effect (+)
2. One buys, one does not: Substitution effect (-)
3. Both buy: no effect

Value of acquisition

Given each other voter acquires information with probability $\alpha \in [0, 1]$:

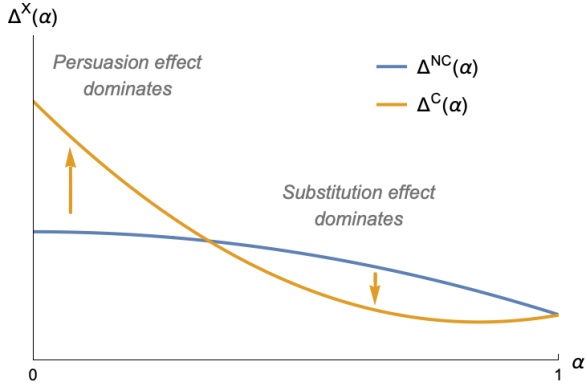
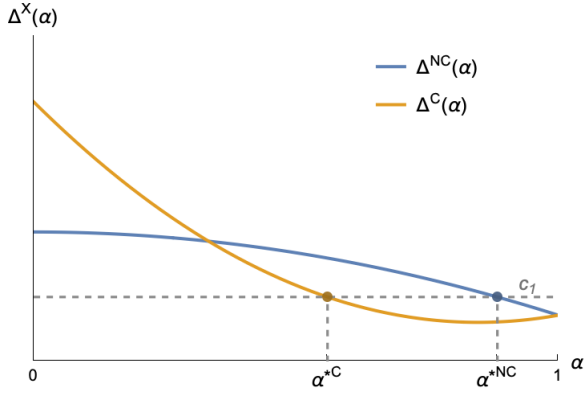


Figure 1: Value of information acquisition

Back

Value of acquisition and equilibrium

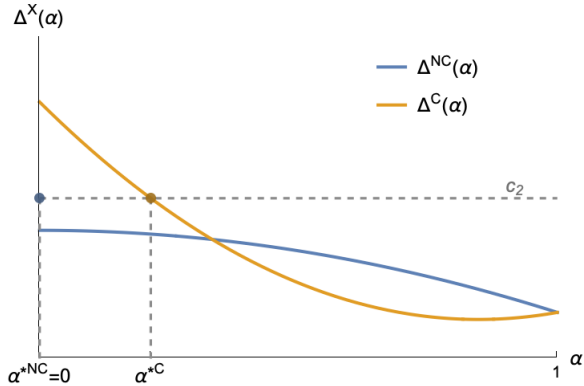
- Equilibra when $c = c_1$



$\rightarrow \alpha^{*C} < \alpha^{*NC}$

Value of acquisition and equilibrium

- Equilibria when $c = c_2$



$\rightarrow \alpha^{*C} > \alpha^{*NC}$

Equilibrium results

Communication's effect on acquisition depends on c:

- For relatively low c, communication reduces info acquisition.
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	Low cost	High cost
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Effects of C	persuasion ↑, **substitution** ↓↓	**persuasion** ↑↑, substitution ↓

Effect on group accuracy and welfare:

- Same two-sided pattern, with different c cutoffs. ▸ More ▸ Figure

Experimental Design

Treatments and main hypotheses

4 treatments: $\{\text{NC, C}\} \times \{\text{Low } c, \text{ High } c\}$; $N = 3$, $q = 0.9$

	Low cost ($c = 0.10$)	High cost ($c = 0.25$)
NC	0.884	0
C	0.560	0.215

Table 1: Equilibrium information acquisition rates

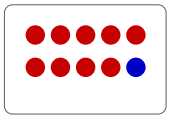
Main hypotheses:

H1 At low info cost, communication reduces info acquisition

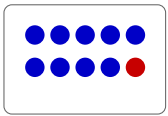
H2 At high info cost, communication increases info acquisition

Experimental Task





Red jar



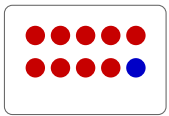
Blue jar

Jar selected

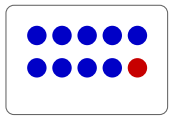
- The computer secretly selects one jar at random (50–50).

Experimental Task





Red jar



Blue jar

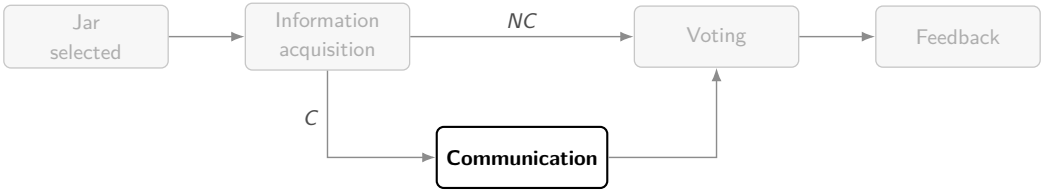
Jar selected

- The computer secretly selects one jar at random (50–50).

Information acquisition

- Each member decides whether to pay a cost c to draw a ball ($q = 0.9$).

Experimental Task



Communication

"I have drawn a red ball"

"I have drawn a blue ball"

No message

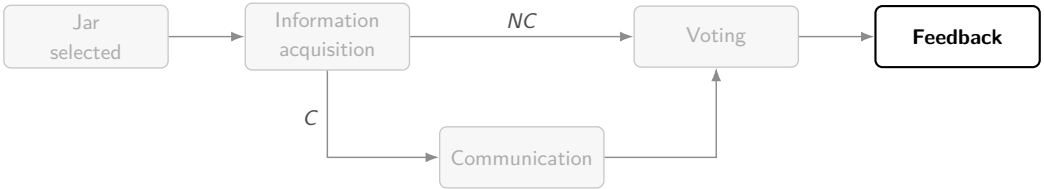
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Voting

- Each member votes for Red or Blue.
- Group decision is determined by majority rule.

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Voting

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Feedback

- Participants see the true jar, group decision, vote counts, and the round payoff.

Procedures and Measures

Procedures

- Between-subject design.
- 30 rounds; random rematching within fixed matching groups of six.
- One randomly selected round paid.
- 288 participants; Tilburg CentERlab, 2025; pre-registered.

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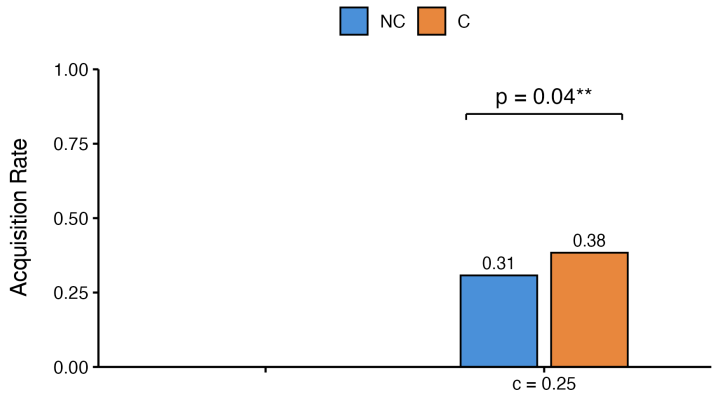
Additional measures

- perceived value of acquisition, beliefs about others' acquisition, and conditional choices.
- risk preference, uncertainty attitude, social preference, demographics

Experimental Results

Communication boosts information acquisition

- Communication increases acquisition when $c = 0.25$ (support H2).

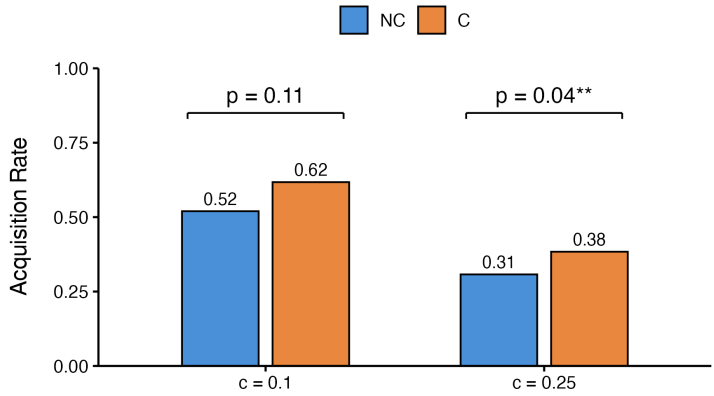


MW test; one-sided for $c = 0.25$, two-sided for $c = 0.1$.

▸ Individual ▸ By-round ▸ Regression ▸ Message and vote

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- No significant difference when $c = 0.1$ (if anything, opposite to H1).



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Communication enhances group outcomes

- Communication improves group accuracy and welfare at both costs.

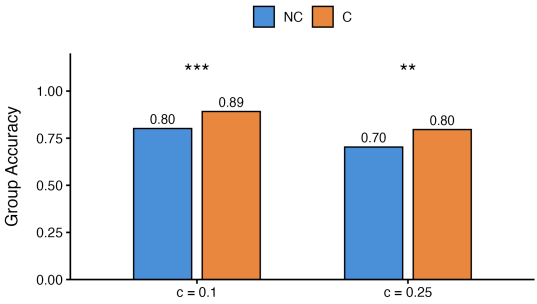


Figure 2: Rate of correct group decisions

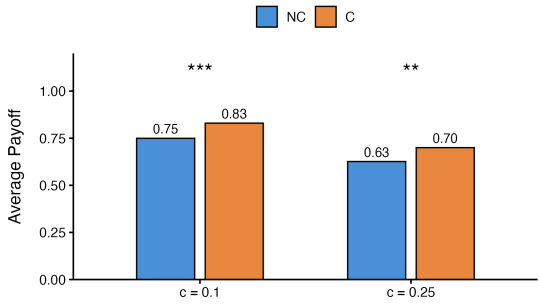


Figure 3: Payoff

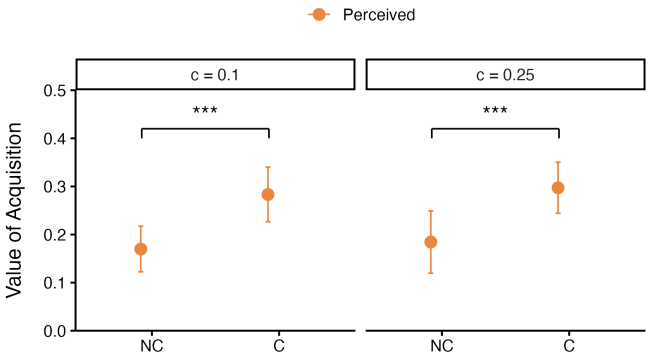
Why is the Downside Missing?

Perceived value of acquisition (PVA)

- PVA $\equiv$ Pr(group correct | I draw) $-$ Pr(group correct | I don't draw), elicited in round 30.

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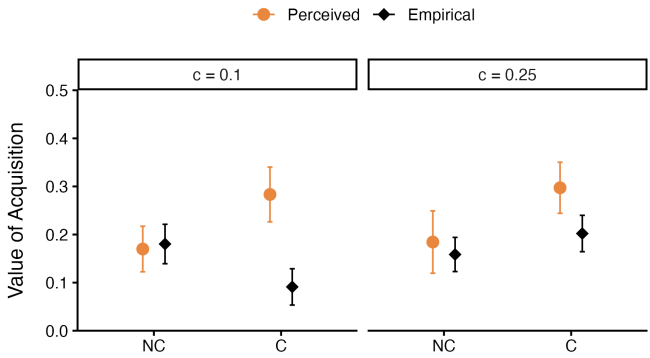


- Communication increases PVA at both costs

PVA predicts acquisition.

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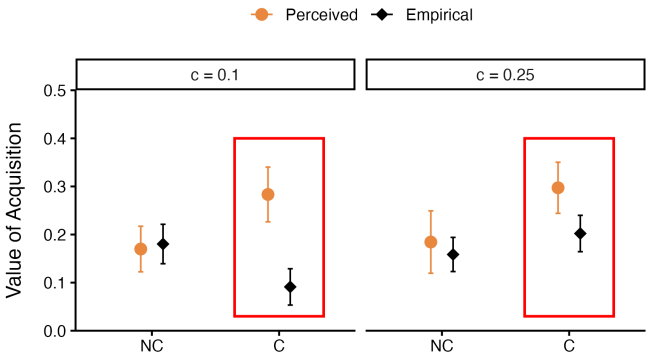


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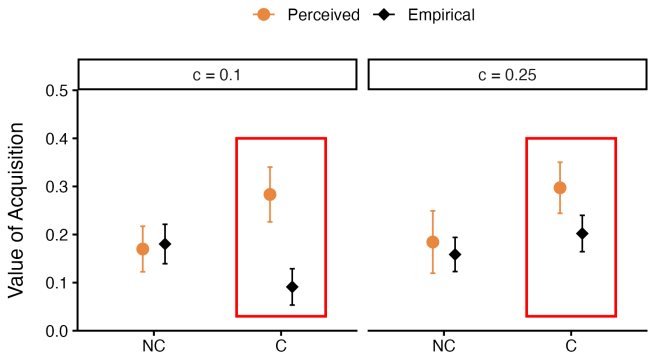
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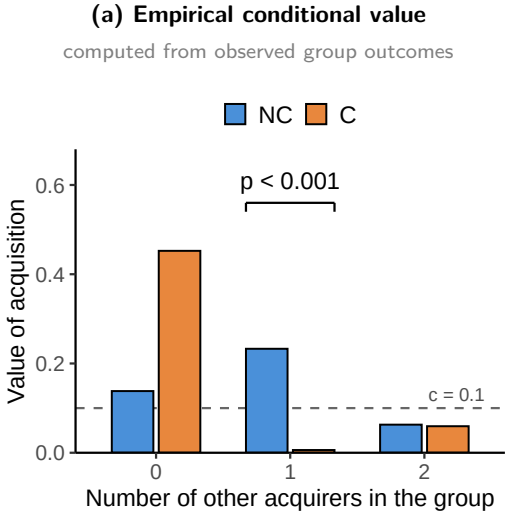
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  - Why? Not from beliefs about others' acquisition

    Beliefs are broadly accurate.

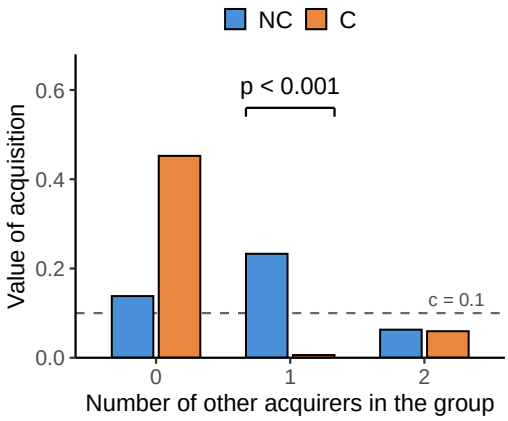
Subjects respond to persuasion, but not to substitution



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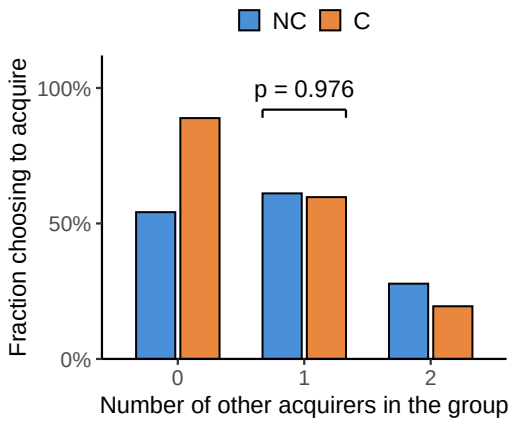
(a) Empirical conditional value

computed from observed group outcomes



(b) Reported acquisition choices

"If 0/1/ 2 others draw, would you draw?" (post-exp)



Conclusion

Conclusion

RQ: How does pre-vote communication affects information acquisition?

Theory: two-sided effects of communication

- Persuasion effect $(+)$ vs. substitution effect $(-)$; which dominates depends on info costs.
- When info is relatively cheap, communication can make everyone worse off.

Experiment: confirms the upside

- Communication increases info acquisition, group accuracy, and welfare.
- Subjects underappreciate substitution effect, overvaluing acquisition under comm.

Implications

- **Institutional design:** turning on/off communication is a lever for shaping info acquisition.
- **Evaluating deliberation:** should not treat the amount of information as fixed.

Thank you! Suggestions welcome!

Appendix

Appendix: Alternative explanations and limitations

- **Equilibrium selection:** Communication is highly informative and voting largely sincere; less-revealing communication or asymmetric acquisition equilibria do not eliminate the two-sided predictions.
- **Risk and social preferences:** Do not explain conditional choices with exactly one other acquirer; risk preferences are not associated with acquisition.
- **Level-k reasoning:** Can eliminate the predicted decrease under certain level-0 assumptions, but does not explain conditional choices with exactly one other acquirer.
- **Quantal response:** Largely explains the more interior acquisition rates, but does not explain the missing downside.

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Appendix: Quantal-response fits

Specification	Estimated parameters	LNC	LC	HNC	HC	RMSE
Observed	–	0.520	0.618	0.308	0.384	–
Nash equilibrium	–	0.884	0.560	0.000	0.215	0.254
Logit QRE	$\hat{\lambda} = 7.556$	0.600	0.521	0.374	0.359	0.072
QRE + CARA	$(\hat{\lambda}, \hat{A}) = (13.620, 5.130)$	0.551	0.533	0.295	0.435	**0.052**
QRE + inequality aversion	$(\hat{\lambda}, \hat{\eta}) = (4.426, 0.999)$	0.580	0.518	0.349	0.343	0.065
QRE + cursed message inference	$(\hat{\lambda}, \hat{\chi}) = (8.970, 0.282)$	0.614	0.599	0.356	0.406	0.055

- **Baseline QRE** captures more interior acquisition rates, but wrong in directions.
- **Extensions:** CARA improves the fit but requires strong risk aversion. Cursed message inference attenuates the low-cost decline and preserves the high-cost increase.

Appendix: No additional value from a second signal

With one signal, a second signal will **not** improve the likelihood that the group selects the correct option. This holds for all q.

- With one signal, the prob that the posterior prefers the truth is

$$q$$

- With two signals, the prob that the posterior prefers the truth is

$$\begin{aligned} & q^2 + 2q(1-q) \cdot \frac{1}{2} \\ =& q^2 + q(1-q) \\ =& q \end{aligned}$$

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Appendix: Expression N=3

Voter 1 and 2 acquire info with prob α. Consider voter 3's incentives.

In game NC,

$$\Delta^{NC}(\alpha) = \left(q - \tfrac{1}{2}\right)\left((1-\alpha)^2 \cdot \tfrac{1}{2} + 2\alpha(1-\alpha) \cdot \tfrac{1}{2} + \alpha^2 \cdot 2q(1-q)\right).$$

In game C,

$$\Delta^{C}(\alpha) = \left(q - \tfrac{1}{2}\right)\left((1-\alpha)^2 \cdot 1 + 2\alpha(1-\alpha) \cdot 0 + \alpha^2 \cdot 2q(1-q)\right).$$

Hence, the difference

$$\Delta^{C}(\alpha) - \Delta^{NC}(\alpha) = \underbrace{\left(q - \tfrac{1}{2}\right)(1-\alpha)^2 \cdot \tfrac{1}{2}}_{\text{persuasion effect}} + \underbrace{\left(q - \tfrac{1}{2}\right) 2\alpha(1-\alpha) \cdot -\tfrac{1}{2}}_{\text{substitution effect}}$$

Appendix: Different n and q

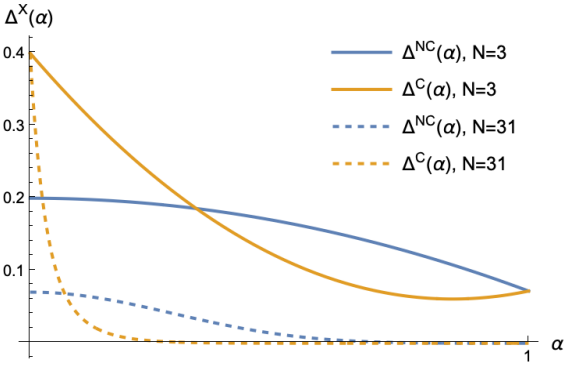


Figure 4: Different n

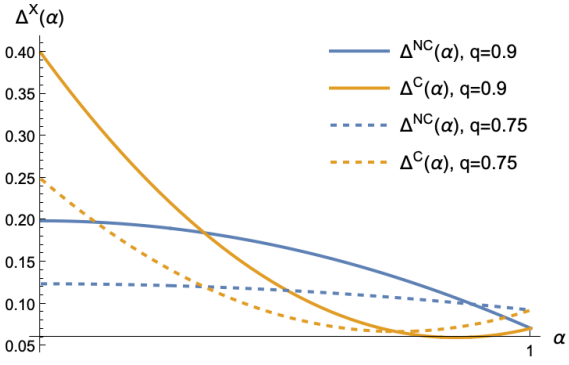
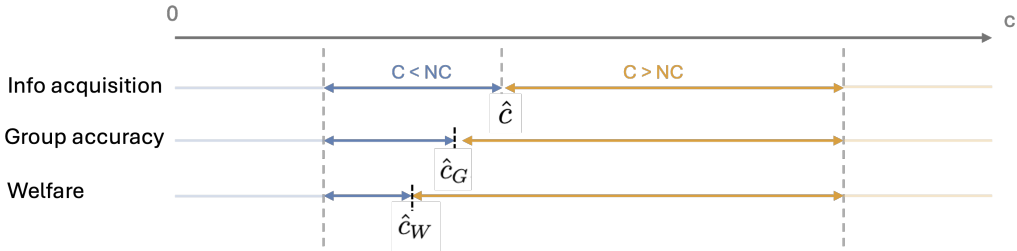


Figure 5: Different q

Appendix: Group accuracy and welfare



- Lower cost cutoffs for G and W than for info acquisition: extra gains come from more efficient information aggregation.
- Cheap-talk communication can be welfare-diminishing.

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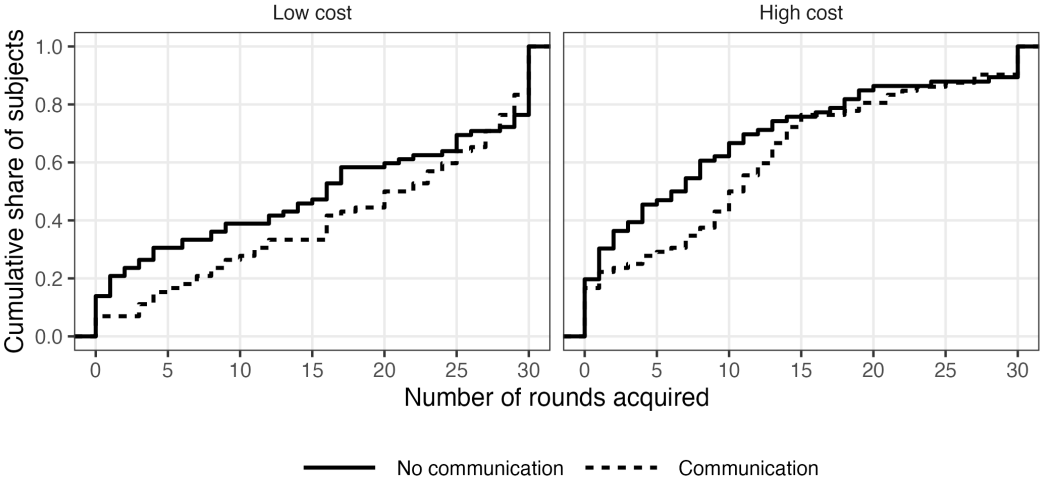
Appendix: More on predictions

	$c = 0.10$			$c = 0.25$		
	m^*	G^*	W^*	m^*	G^*	W^*
NC equilibrium	**0.884**	**0.942**	**0.871**	0	0.500	0.500
C equilibrium	0.560	0.879	0.823	**0.215**	**0.707**	**0.653**

Appendix: Pure-strategy equilibrium

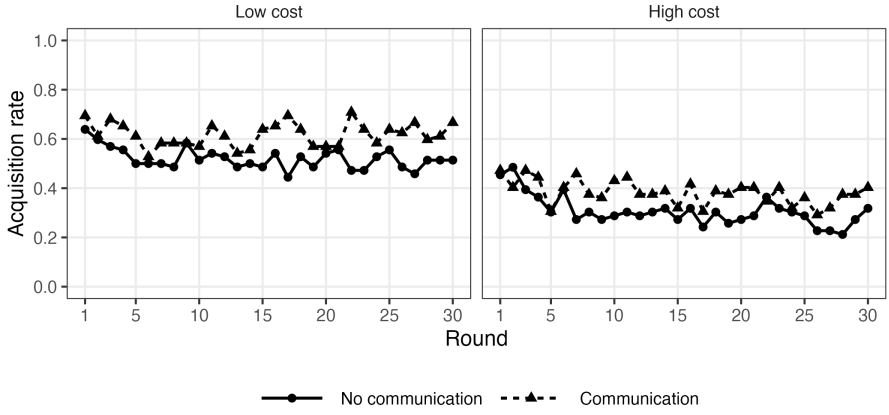
	$c = 0.10$	$c = 0.25$
C	One buys	One buys
NC	Two buy	None buy

Appendix: Information acquisition - individual



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Appendix: Acquisition by round



- $c = 0.1$: First 15 rounds = Last 15 round
- $c = 0.25$: First 15 rounds > Last 15 round, significant Back

Appendix: Regression

Table 2: Effect of Communication on Draw Decisions (OLS)

	Dependent Variable: Draw (0/1)			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Comm	0.087**	0.098*	0.114**	0.115**
	(0.035)	(0.052)	(0.054)	(0.048)
High Cost	-0.223***	-0.212***	-0.212***	-0.220***
	(0.034)	(0.055)	(0.055)	(0.051)
Comm × High Cost		-0.021	-0.021	-0.032
		(0.069)	(0.069)	(0.067)
First-half Rounds and × Comm			✓	✓
Individual Controls				✓
Comm effect at High Cost		0.076**	0.092**	0.083**
Observations	8,460	8,460	8,460	8,460

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. SEs clustered at the matching-group level. Stars for the joint test row based on one-sided tests. Individual controls: uncertainty attitude, social preference, and gender.

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Appendix: Messages and voting

1. Communication is highly informative:
   - draw: no lie
   - not draw: 10% lie at $c = 0.25$, 16% lie at $c = 0.1$

Empirical message accuracy: 86.4% at the low cost and 84.2% at high cost

2. Voting is almost always sincere:
   - In C, when there is a majority message in the group, subjects vote with the majority message in 97% of cases at both c.
   - In NC, subjects vote according to their signal in 99.7% of cases. 50/50 when uninformed.

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Appendix: Regression full results

Effect of Communication on Signal Acquisition

	Dependent variable:				
	Signal Acquire				
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Comm	0.087**	0.098*	0.114**	0.115**	0.038
	(0.035)	(0.052)	(0.054)	(0.048)	(0.046)
High cost	-0.223***	-0.212***	-0.212***	-0.220***	-0.231***
	(0.034)	(0.055)	(0.055)	(0.051)	(0.040)
Comm × High cost		-0.021	-0.021	-0.032	-0.032
		(0.069)	(0.069)	(0.067)	(0.065)
Early round			0.039***	0.039***	0.039***
			(0.015)	(0.015)	(0.015)
Comm × Early round			-0.032*	-0.032*	-0.032*
			(0.019)	(0.019)	(0.019)
Perceived value of acquisition					0.669***
					(0.073)
Female				-0.041	-0.026
				(0.045)	(0.038)
Risk tolerance				0.0004	0.001
				(0.001)	(0.001)
Uncertainty tolerance				0.007	0.004
				(0.008)	(0.007)
Pro-sociality				0.006***	0.006***
				(0.001)	(0.001)
Observations	8,460	8,460	8,460	8,460	8,460

Appendix: Regression including PVA

	Dependent Variable: Draw (0/1)				
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Comm	0.087**	0.098*	0.114**	0.115**	0.038
	(0.035)	(0.052)	(0.054)	(0.048)	(0.046)
High Cost	-0.223***	-0.212***	-0.212***	-0.220***	-0.231***
	(0.034)	(0.055)	(0.055)	(0.051)	(0.040)
Comm × High Cost		-0.021	-0.021	-0.032	-0.032
		(0.069)	(0.069)	(0.067)	(0.065)
Perceived value of acquisition					0.669***
					(0.073)
First-half Rounds and × Comm			✓	✓	✓
Individual Controls				✓	✓
Comm effect at High Cost		0.076**	0.092**	0.083**	0.006
Observations	8,460	8,460	8,460	8,460	8,460

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. SEs clustered at the matching-group level. Stars for the joint test row are based on one-sided tests. Individual controls: uncertainty attitude, social preference, and gender.

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Appendix: PVA

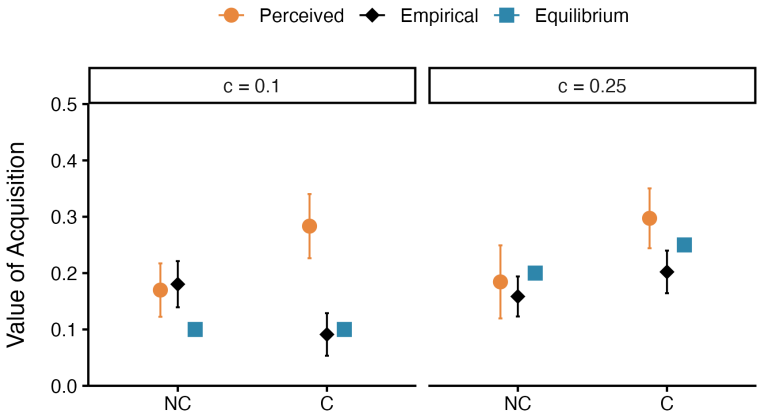
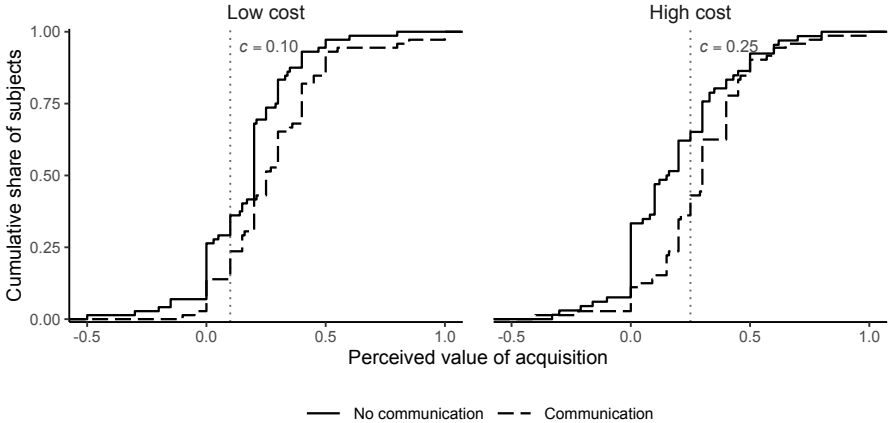


Figure 6: Value of Acquisition: perceived v.s. empirical v.s. equilibrium

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Appendix: distribution of PVA



Appendix: Beliefs about others draw behavior at c=0.1

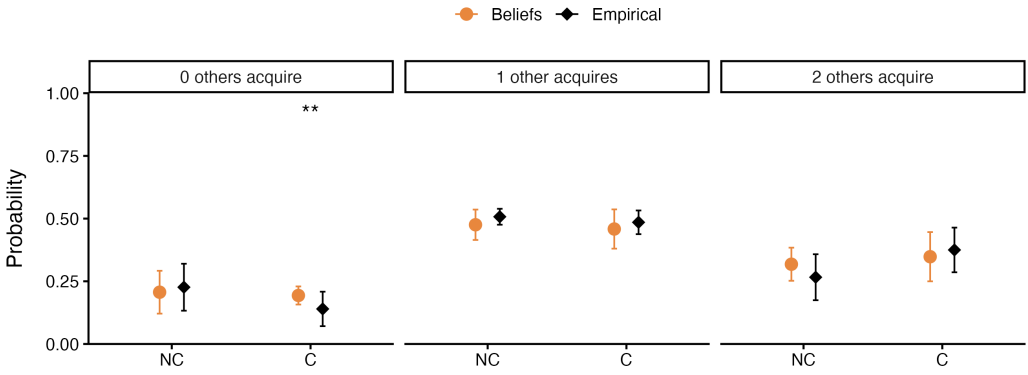


Figure 7: Beliefs about others draw at c=0.1: fairly accurate

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Appendix: Beliefs about others draw behavior at c=0.25

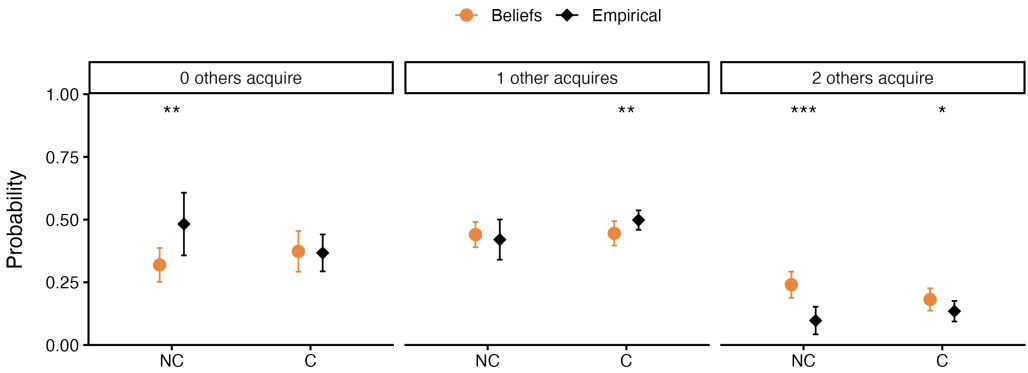


Figure 8: Beliefs about others draw at c=0.25: overestimate